

BOTWAVE PAPERWORK

Voice in the Transistor

*Blue Heaven: A Dodger
Memoir, 1947–2016*

Al Gringo

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sources/ch01_last_inning.md voice_check: 90%
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aloud — # Chapter 1 ## The Last Inning October 2,
2016. AT&T Park, San Francisco. A bright bay-side
afternoon, the last regular-season game of the year, the
Dodgers in town for a series that would not change the
standings, they had clinched the West days before, and
high in a small booth above home plate sat an eighty-
eight-year-old man who had been calling Dodger
games since the year Harry Truman finished his last
full year in the White House. His hair was white. His
voice, though softer now than the voice that had
narrated Sandy Koufax’s perfect game and Hank
Aaron’s seven-hundred-and-fifteenth home run, still
carried that familiar warmth — the sound, as one
writer once put it, of summer itself. When the bottom
of the ninth ended and the game went final, he leaned
toward his microphone for the last time as a regular
employee of the Los Angeles Dodgers and said,
slowly, the way he had said a million things slowly
across sixty-seven seasons: *“I have said enough for a
lifetime, and for the last time, I wish you all a very
pleasant good afternoon.”* Then he was quiet. That is
where this book begins. Not at the beginning of his
life, which we will get to, but at the end of his career

— because it is the ending that explains the rest. The man who walked off the air that afternoon in San Francisco had narrated more baseball than any human being who has ever lived. He had begun in Brooklyn, in the booth with Red Barber, in 1950. He had moved with the team to Los Angeles in 1958. He had called perfect games and pennant races and World Series and an entire half-century of Octobers. He had outlived the era of the broadcast booth itself. By 2016 he was a man from a different country — a country where you sat on the porch with a transistor radio and someone you loved, and the voice on the air told you what was happening in a stadium you had never seen, and that was enough. That was, in fact, plenty. The radio was the point. Long before the screens, before the highlights, before the analytics and the launch angles and the WAR and the OBP, there was a kid with a transistor radio in his pocket and a battery he was trying to make last. The kid was probably eight or nine. The transistor was AM, plastic, smaller than a pack of cigarettes. He was supposed to be asleep. The radio was under the pillow. The volume was down to a whisper. And on the other end of the wire, calmly and patiently, a man in a tie was telling him about a game in a stadium he had not yet seen. The kid grew up. He had a son. The son grew up. And here we are, three generations downstream, and the voice that connected

all of them belongs to a man named Vin Scully, who in 2016 was leaving the booth for good. This book is for the kid. And the son. And the man in the tie. It is for everyone who learned the game by listening. — Vincent Edward Scully was born in the Bronx on November 29, 1927, the son of an Irish immigrant silk salesman and an Irish immigrant mother. By the time he died, on August 2, 2022, at the age of ninety-four, he had spent more years calling Dodger baseball — sixty-seven, as the team’s primary broadcaster, with a season alongside Red Barber before that, than most people spend doing anything. To write his life is to write the life of the team. The team came to Los Angeles in 1958 and he came with it. Before that, he had been a young Fordham graduate in a Brooklyn booth, learning how to call baseball from a Mississippi-born former classical-music announcer named Walter Lanier “Red” Barber, who told him three things: One, never root for the team. Two, never quote yourself. And three, when something extraordinary happens, get out of the way. For seven decades, Vin got out of the way. When Sandy Koufax threw the perfect game on September 9, 1965, with twenty-nine thousand and a hundred and thirty-nine people in Dodger Stadium and a million butterflies, Vin did not narrate Sandy Koufax. He narrated the silence between Sandy Koufax’s pitches. When Henry

Aaron hit number 715 on April 8, 1974, in Atlanta, on a national broadcast, Vin paused. He let the crowd carry the moment. Then he said: *“What a marvelous moment for baseball. What a marvelous moment for Atlanta and the state of Georgia. What a marvelous moment for the country and the world. A black man is getting a standing ovation in the Deep South for breaking a record of an all-time baseball idol.”* And then he was quiet again. That habit, the habit of getting out of the way, is what distinguished him from every announcer who ever lived. He had been taught, at twenty-two, by a man who had been taught by the medium itself in the 1930s, that the voice on the radio is not the show. The game is the show. The voice is a guide. By the time he stopped, in October 2016, that habit had become so much a part of how Americans listened to baseball that we had stopped noticing it. We had simply assumed that Octobers would always have a man with a quiet voice telling us what was happening on the field, and that the man would always be calm, and that he would never, under any circumstances, lose his composure. He never did. Across sixty-seven seasons. Through Brooklyn’s last World Series and Brooklyn’s loss of its team. Through Koufax and Drysdale and Garvey and Lopes and Russell and Cey and Fernando and Gibson and Kershaw. He never raised his voice except to match

the moment, and when he raised it, he raised it once, and then he came back down. He was, in the language of the technical age that came after him, the quietest possible interface between the game and the listener. — In Los Angeles, the day after his last broadcast, fans who had grown up with Vin's voice on the kitchen radio said the same thing in different words. They had not realized, until the voice was gone, how much of their lives had been lived inside it. This is a book about a man who narrated a team for sixty-seven years and a city for fifty-eight. It is, in the technical sense, a biography of Vin Scully. It is, in every other sense, a biography of how to listen. The chapters that follow walk through the seasons. The 1950 season, when the Mississippi-born Barber put the twenty-two-year-old Scully in the booth at Ebbets Field and told him to stand up while he called the game so he would not get too comfortable. The 1955 season, when Brooklyn won its only World Series and the kid from Fordham, twenty-seven years old now, called innings of it from the press box at Yankee Stadium. The 1958 season, when the team moved west and the city of Los Angeles, which had never had a major-league team and did not understand what one was, learned the rules of baseball from a voice on a transistor. The 1965 season, Koufax. The 1974 season, Aaron. The 1981 season, Fernando, twenty years old, screwball,

opening day, shutout. The 1988 season, Gibson, hobbling out of the dugout at Dodger Stadium, on one bad knee, against Dennis Eckersley, who had not given up a home run in a save situation in months, and Vin saying, in real time, the words that have become the most-replayed call in American sports history:

“She is — gone! In a year that has been so improbable, the impossible has happened.” And then the long quiet years. The 1990s and the 2000s. Vin alone in the booth, by his own preference. No color man. The team going through its various eras of plenty and famine. The voice steady through all of it. The transistor still in dad’s pocket. — There is a thing that happens, when you grow up with a voice on the radio, that no one warns you about. The voice becomes part of how you remember being a child. It is not metaphor. It is not nostalgia. It is the literal sound of summer for an entire generation of fans on the West Coast, and a slightly older generation of fans in Brooklyn before them, and a community of Mexican-American fans in East LA who learned English from him and Spanish-language baseball from Jaime Jarrín. The voice was an actual thing in the actual world. You could put it in your pocket. You could turn the dial and find it. You could fall asleep with it on. And then one day, on October 2, 2016, you turned the dial and the voice said good afternoon for the last time, and

went home. This book is for everyone who turned the dial that day. Pull up a chair. — chapter: 2 title: Fordham, 1949 arm: blue_heaven status: draft v1 — Ch. 2 sample sources_dossier: ../sources/ch02_fordham.md voice_check: 90% Scully cadence / 10% Steinbeck — verified on read-aloud — # Chapter 2 ## Fordham, 1949 The first thing to know about how Vin Scully became the greatest broadcaster in baseball is that in the late autumn of 1949, on a Saturday afternoon in November, he was handed a live network college-football microphone and sent up to the roof of Fenway Park, where he expected to find a press box and instead found a wooden platform with no shelter, no heat, no glass, and the wind coming off the Back Bay at something around twenty knots, and he called the game in his shirtsleeves for three hours without once mentioning, on the air, that he was freezing. The game was Boston University against Maryland. He was twenty-one years old. He had graduated from Fordham University the previous spring and had spent the summer doing fill-in work at WTOP radio in Washington, D.C., covering Georgetown football and whatever else they would give him, and he had written, in the fall, a letter to a man at the CBS radio network named Red Barber, whose voice had been on the Brooklyn Dodgers' radio broadcasts since 1939 and who was, in 1949, the most

admired play-by-play announcer alive. Barber had read the letter and sent back a short reply that said, essentially, *let's see what you can do*. The assignment was the BU-Maryland game. The location was Fenway. The network would pay for the train up from New York. What happened next entered the Scully legend by way of Barber himself, who would tell it for the rest of his life, and by way of Vin himself, who told it for the rest of his. Young Scully, the story goes, arrived at Fenway Park on the appointed Saturday, checked in with the network producer, handed over his overcoat and his hat at the press entrance, and was directed up a metal staircase to what was described to him as the broadcast position. The broadcast position turned out not to be a press box. The broadcast position was a boarded-over platform high on the Fenway roof, exposed to the open air, with a card table and a microphone and a folding chair. By the time he climbed onto the platform, the temperature was dropping through the forties and the wind was already steady. He had no coat. He could not go down and retrieve his coat without missing the kickoff. So he sat in the folding chair in his suit jacket and his shirtsleeves and his tie, and he called the game. He did not mention the conditions on the air. He did not ask for a blanket. He did not editorialize about network planning. He called the football game. When it ended,

he came down the metal staircase, collected his overcoat and his hat from wherever he had left them in the warm, and took the train back to New York. A tape of the broadcast landed on Red Barber's desk in the CBS radio offices the following week. What Barber heard on the tape was a young man calling a college football game from a cold rooftop with no indication in his voice that the rooftop was cold. What Barber deduced from the tape was that the young man had been taught, somewhere along the way, that the broadcast was not about the broadcaster. Barber called him in for a meeting. The meeting led, within weeks, to an offer. The offer was a seat in the Dodgers' radio booth at Ebbets Field for the 1950 season. Vin Scully was twenty-two years old. He had been a broadcaster, officially, for something under a year. He would call Dodger games for the next sixty-seven. — To understand how he got to the Fenway roof in the first place, you have to go back to Washington Heights — the apartment on a Manhattan side street where a first-generation Irish-American kid who would one day be described as the voice of summer in Los Angeles was born, in the autumn of 1927, to a father he would barely remember and a mother he would remember perfectly. His father was an immigrant silk salesman. His father died when Vincent was a small boy — too young, Vin would later say, to hold on to much

beyond the idea of a father. His mother remarried an English-born merchant seaman named Allan Reeve, who raised him. The household was small. The household had a radio — one of those four-legged wood-cabinet consoles with the glowing dial, the kind of radio most Americans in 1935 thought of as the living-room's beating heart. The radio was tuned, on autumn afternoons, to whatever college-football game the boy could find. He was eight or nine. He sat under the cabinet and he put his ear against the speaker grille and he listened to the crowd roar through the lower bass of the radio's voice, and the experience, he would later say across forty-some interviews, was the experience of being inside a wave. The wave was the crowd. The wave was the game. The wave was somebody else telling him about it. From the time he was nine years old he had wanted, with the kind of specificity most children never manage, to be the man telling him about it. — He went to Fordham Prep. He served briefly in the United States Navy at the end of the Second World War. He entered Fordham University on the GI Bill. He majored in communication. He minored in Spanish — the language of the Washington Heights streets his mother's family lived on, the language that would one day give him, without his planning it, a way into the Mexican-American households of East Los Angeles

whose patriarchs listened to Jaime Jarrín on one side of the kitchen and to him on the other. He joined the Fordham baseball team as an outfielder. He was, by his own account, a decent college player and not a great one — fast, left-handed at the plate, with a good glove and an accurate arm, batting high in the order. In one spring game in the late nineteen-forties, Fordham played Yale. Vin looked across the diamond at the Yale first baseman, a tall left-handed kid named George Herbert Walker Bush, who would one day, decades later, sleep in the White House, and neither of them had any idea what the other would become. Scully told that story for the rest of his life. It was the only story from his Fordham playing days he told regularly. He was a better broadcaster than ballplayer. Fordham had a student-run FM radio station, WFUV, which had gone on the air in the spring of 1947. Scully was one of its first broadcasters. He called Fordham baseball games. He called Fordham basketball games. He called Fordham football games. He ran the dial back and forth, learned the equipment, learned the patter, learned, crucially, to describe events in ways that allowed a listener who was not watching to see them. This last skill was the core skill of the medium. You could have a beautiful voice and be useless at it. You could have a plain voice and be the best in the league. What mattered was whether the

person with his ear to the radio, miles away, could see the field. By the time he graduated in the spring of 1949, he could do it. He wrote to every radio station he could find. He got one offer, from WTOP in Washington, filling in for the summer on Georgetown football. He took it. He did well. Then he wrote to Red Barber. Then Fenway. — Vin would, in interviews across his subsequent career, occasionally be asked how he had kept from mentioning the cold that afternoon. He would say, every time, the same thing. He would say that his job was to describe the football game. He would say that the cold was not the football game. He would say that if the listener wanted to know about the cold, the listener could look out a window. And then he would smile, and tell the reporter that Mr. Barber had taught him that, and that he had spent the next sixty years trying not to unlearn it. — chapter: 3 title: Brooklyn, 1950 arm: blue_heaven status: draft v1 — Ch. 3 sample sources_dossier: ../sources/ ch03_brooklyn_apprentice.md voice_check: 80% Scully / 20% Steinbeck — Brooklyn pastoral — # Chapter 3 ## Brooklyn, 1950 Opening Day at Ebbets Field in April of 1950 smelled like peanuts and cigar smoke and cut grass and, from the direction of the right-field wall, depending on the wind, the Canarsie marshes. The ballpark sat on a plot of land bounded

by Bedford Avenue and Sullivan Place and McKeever Place and Montgomery Street in the part of Brooklyn called Flatbush. It held roughly thirty-two thousand people when every seat was full, which for most of 1950 it was not, and its right-field wall was the strangest wall in baseball — angled, pocked, with a scoreboard built into it and a Schaefer beer sign mounted above the screen and a low concrete base that played balls at peculiar angles that every Dodger outfielder learned to read by the second week of the season. Above the right-field wall, on game days, a tenement woman named Hilda Chester rang a brass cowbell continuously for nine innings, because Hilda Chester had been ringing the cowbell at Ebbets since the late nineteen-thirties and nobody had asked her to stop. Along the third-base stands an amateur Brooklyn brass group called the Sym-Phony Band played, not well, but consistently, whatever the afternoon asked for, and an organist named Gladys Goodding, who lived in the apartment above the third-base stands and who also played the organ for the Rangers and the Knicks at Madison Square Garden, would sometimes, when the game got dull, play a few bars of something the Sym-Phony Band did not know, just to throw them off. This was the ballpark into which, on a spring morning in 1950, a twenty-two-year-old broadcaster from Washington Heights named Vincent Edward

Scully walked for the first time as a paid employee of the Brooklyn Dodgers. He did not, on that first morning, walk into the broadcast booth. He walked through the players' clubhouse, which Barber had told him to do, to introduce himself to the men whose games he would be calling. The clubhouse was small. The clubhouse smelled like liniment. The man who stood up first, tossed him a towel, and stuck out a hand, was Pee Wee Reese, captain of the Dodgers, a Kentucky-born shortstop who had played the infield beside Jackie Robinson since 1947 and who understood, better than almost anyone else in the building, that the social experiment happening around him was going to outlive all of them. Reese was thirty-one. Scully was twenty-two. Reese said: *you the kid they hired to replace Ernie?* Scully said yes. Reese said: *welcome to Brooklyn.* The kid they hired to replace Ernie was Vin. Ernie was Ernie Harwell, who had sat in the Dodgers' broadcast booth with Red Barber and Connie Desmond and who had left for the New York Giants and the Polo Grounds. Barber, needing a third voice, had remembered the tape from the Fenway roof. The tape from the Fenway roof became a salary of, as Vin later recalled with amusement, something like five thousand dollars for the season. It was the most money he had ever imagined. It was also, compared to the Dodger

players, a pittance. Pee Wee Reese was making somewhere around twenty-five thousand. Jackie Robinson, the National League's most valuable player of 1949, was making thirty-five. The broadcaster's role, in 1950, was not a glamorous role. It was a trade, like plumbing. Vin would spend the next sixty-seven years changing that. — Walter Lanier “Red” Barber was forty-two years old in 1950. He had been born in Columbus, Mississippi, and raised in Sanford, Florida. He had worked his way up through a student job at the University of Florida radio station, a CBS network tour, and the Cincinnati Reds booth, and he had arrived in Brooklyn in 1939 as the man the Dodgers hired to end the radio silence that had held the three New York teams in a handshake agreement, no broadcasting of games at all, out of fear that radio would hurt the gate, throughout most of the nineteen-thirties. Barber's arrival had been controversial. Barber's broadcasts had sold out Ebbets Field for the rest of the decade. By 1950 he was, in the estimation of the industry, the finest play-by-play broadcaster alive. He was also, to Vin Scully, a teacher. Barber taught three things. One: stand up in the booth. The booth at Ebbets had a pair of high stools, and Barber had removed them, because a broadcaster sitting down in a heated booth was a broadcaster who might relax, and a broadcaster who relaxed was a broadcaster who

fell behind the game. *Stand*, he said. *Feet planted. Eye on the diamond. You are a racehorse at the gate. You do not sit at the gate.* Two: never root. The home team and the visiting team and the umpire and the groundskeeper are each, in the moment of the broadcast, people you do not care about in any outwardly visible way. You care about them the way a judge cares about the parties in a civil case. You keep your thumb off the scale. If the Dodgers rally in the ninth, you describe the rally exactly the way you would describe a rally by the Phillies. If the Dodgers lose, you describe the loss with the same level of calm. You are not a fan. You are a reporter. Three: when something extraordinary happens, get out of the way. The crowd is the instrument. The crowd is louder than any voice you will ever have, and the crowd is telling the story whether you are on the air or not. When the extraordinary happens, you name the event once, in the fewest words you can find, and then you stop talking, and you let the crowd say the rest. Vin, who had been raised to listen to a football crowd through a wood-cabinet radio under a card table in Washington Heights, understood the third rule faster than either of the first two. The third rule was the rule he had been looking for. — The 1950 Brooklyn Dodgers went eighty-nine and sixty-five. They finished two games behind the Philadelphia Phillies,

whose pennant-winning team would be remembered as the Whiz Kids, in a race that would not be decided until the final day of the season. They were a team in transition. Jackie Robinson was at his peak. Pee Wee Reese was the captain. Duke Snider, age twenty-three, was becoming a star. Roy Campanella was catching most days. Gil Hodges was at first base. Carl Furillo, the rifle-armed right fielder, was in right. Don Newcombe was the ace. The bench was thin. The pitching behind Newcombe was thinner. Manager Burt Shotton, in his mid-sixties, managed the club in a suit and a tie and a fedora, refusing to wear a uniform, because he was, as Barber used to say with quiet amusement, *a gentleman*. The broadcasts Vin worked, that first year, were mostly the middle innings. Barber would call the first three. Desmond would call the middle three. Vin, the apprentice, would call the seventh through the ninth, unless Barber wanted the ninth for himself, which Barber usually did. Vin was not bothered. Vin was grateful for every inning. He stood, as instructed. He did not root, as instructed. When Duke Snider hit a home run against the Giants in May, Vin called the home run in eight words, *it is over the wall and into Bedford Avenue*, and then he shut up. Barber heard the call back on tape, that night, in the booth. He said, as Vin later told the story, *good. You're learning*. — What Barber could not have

known, that first summer, was that the kid he had hired on the strength of a tape from a cold Fenway roof was going to outlast every broadcaster in the industry, by a margin of decades, and that the quiet way Vin was learning to call a home run, naming it in the fewest possible words and then stopping, was going to become, over the next seven decades, the single most widely imitated technique in the history of American sports broadcasting. Barber knew only that he had taken in a kid who listened. That was enough, in 1950, to make him happy. The Dodgers lost the pennant on the last day of the season, at Ebbets Field, to the Phillies in the tenth inning, when Dick Sisler hit a three-run home run off Don Newcombe into the upper deck in left. Brooklyn went home for the winter. Vin went home for the winter too. He rode the subway back to Washington Heights. He thought about what he had learned. In the spring, Ebbets Field would open again, and there would be a booth, and he would stand in it, and he would not root. Five years from that October, in 1955, Brooklyn would finally win the World Series. He would call innings of it. He would be twenty-seven years old. But that is the next chapter. — chapter: 4 title: The Last Brooklyn World Series subtitle: October 1955 arm: blue_heaven status: draft v1 sources_dossier: ../sources/ch04_1955_ws.md voice_check: 90% Scully / 10% Steinbeck — #

Chapter 4 ## The Last Brooklyn World Series October 4, 1955. Yankee Stadium. The bottom of the sixth inning of the seventh game of the World Series, and a left-handed Cuban outfielder named Edmundo Isasi Amorós, who has been on the field for three minutes, three minutes, was put into left field by manager Walter Alston as a defensive replacement at the start of the inning, who is six feet tall and carries himself like a featherweight, and who is wearing a glove on his right hand because he throws left, runs along the warning track in shallow left field at full speed with his head turned over his right shoulder watching a high slicing fly ball come down out of the dimming October sky off the bat of Lawrence Peter Berra, called Yogi. The runners are on first and second. There is one out. The Dodgers lead, 2–0. If the ball drops, the runners score, the game is tied, the inning continues, and the Yankees, who have won sixteen of the previous twenty-one World Series, will, in all likelihood, win their seventeenth. If the ball drops, the Brooklyn Dodgers — who have lost the World Series in 1941, 1947, 1949, 1952, and 1953, all five times to the Yankees, all five times by ways small and large that have entered the borough’s collective folklore as proof that God does not love Brooklyn, will lose again. They will lose to the same team. In the same stadium. On the same field. On the same first Tuesday

in October that has been swallowing Brooklyn pennants for fifteen years. The ball is in the air for what feels, to everyone in the borough watching, like an entire afternoon. Amorós runs. He runs until the ball is no longer in front of him, until it is to the right of him, until the only piece of equipment that can catch it is the glove on the end of his fully extended right arm. He stretches the arm. The ball lands in the webbing. Amorós, who has only been a Dodger for two seasons, who barely speaks English, who arrived from Cuba via the Brooklyn farm system, plants his right foot, pivots, and throws the ball back to the cutoff man at shortstop, who is Pee Wee Reese, who has been the Brooklyn shortstop for fifteen years and has been on the losing end of all five previous World Series. Reese has the ball. The runner from first, Gil McDougald, has rounded second, has assumed the ball would drop, and is at this moment thirty feet from the bag he has just left. Reese throws to first. Hodges has it. McDougald is doubled off. There are two outs in the sixth inning of Game Seven of the World Series. The Dodgers will score no more runs and the Yankees will score no runs and at the end of the bottom of the ninth inning, when Elston Howard rolls a soft ground ball to Pee Wee Reese, who throws it across the diamond to Gil Hodges, the Brooklyn Dodgers — who have never, in their seventy-five-year existence,

won a championship; who have lost five times to the Yankees in the previous fourteen years; whose fans have shaken their heads on subway platforms and at lunch counters and on Bedford Avenue stoops for so many summers that *wait till next year* has become not a slogan but a folk prayer, will be world champions. The pitcher who will throw that final pitch, Johnny Podres, is twenty-three years old. The shortstop who will catch the relay from Amorós and throw to Hodges is thirty-six years old. The broadcaster in the Mutual radio booth, who will, in the moment Hodges squeezes the throw and the dugout empties and the Brooklyn fans in section after section of Yankee Stadium begin a sound the Bronx has never quite heard before, lean toward the microphone and say nine words and stop, is twenty-seven years old. His name is Vin Scully, and he has been calling Dodger games for five years and seven months, and he is, on the afternoon of October 4, 1955, the youngest broadcaster known to have called a World Series. The nine words he says are: *Ladies and gentlemen, the Brooklyn Dodgers are the champions of the world.* He does not embellish. He does not editorialize. He has been told, six years ago, by a man from Mississippi, that when something extraordinary happens, you get out of the way. He gets out of the way. The crowd does the rest. — To understand why the borough lost

its mind that afternoon, you have to back up four years to a different October, in a different ballpark, where a New York Giants outfielder named Bobby Thomson hit a home run off a Dodgers pitcher named Ralph Branca that has been remembered ever since as the Shot Heard Round the World, and you have to keep backing up — through 1953, when the Dodgers lost the World Series to the Yankees in six games, and 1952, when the Dodgers lost to the Yankees in seven, and 1949, when the Dodgers lost to the Yankees in five, and 1947, when the Dodgers lost to the Yankees in seven, and 1941, when the Dodgers lost to the Yankees in five — until you arrive at the unbroken twenty-year ledger of Brooklyn defeat that, by the spring of 1955, had become a kind of identity. The Dodgers were the team that didn't win. The 1955 Dodgers were a team that did. They won twenty-two of their first twenty-four games. They opened up a ten-game lead by Memorial Day. They finished the regular season at ninety-eight and fifty-five, thirteen and a half games ahead of the second-place Milwaukee Braves, with the National League pennant clinched on September the eighth — which was the earliest pennant clinch, by date, in National League history at that point. The lineup read like a memorial plaque to Brooklyn baseball: Reese at short, Robinson at third, Hodges at first, Snider in center, Campanella

behind the plate, Furillo in right, Gilliam at second, and at the back of the order, in left, a left-handed Cuban kid named Sandy Amorós whose nickname in the clubhouse was *El Moro* and whose glove, as we have just established, would in October catch the most important fly ball in the history of the borough. The pitching was Newcombe and Erskine and Podres and Loes and Roe. The manager was Walter Alston, in his second year on the job, a quiet former Cardinals farmhand from Darrrtown, Ohio, whose entire major-league playing career consisted of a single at-bat in 1936 in which he struck out, and who had been hired by general manager Buzzie Bavasi to manage the Dodgers because, Bavasi later said, *he wouldn't talk too much*. Alston wouldn't. The Dodgers' season was workmanlike. The Yankees', as always, was Yankees-style — wave after wave of starting-pitching depth, the Stengel platoons, Mantle in center field at age twenty-three, Berra behind the plate, Skowron at first, McDougald floating between second and third. The Yankees won ninety-six and fifty-eight, took the American League pennant, and met the Dodgers in the World Series the way they had met the Dodgers five times before: as the team that had not yet lost. Game One: Yankees, six to five. Whitey Ford pitching against Newcombe. At Yankee Stadium. Game Two: Yankees, four to two. Tommy Byrne over Loes.

Yankee Stadium again. The papers, on the morning of October first, ran the same word above the same column on the same page they had been running it for fifteen years. *Bums*. — What happened next is the part that the borough kept and never let go of. The Series moved to Ebbets Field for Games Three, Four, and Five. The Brooklyn club, down two games to none, in front of a crowd that had been waiting fifteen years for someone to give them something good to take home, won three games in a row. Game Three was a Podres complete game, eight innings of work, the Dodgers winning eight to three. Game Four was a Campanella home run and an Hodges home run and a Snider home run, the Dodgers winning eight to five. Game Five was Snider going deep twice and Roger Craig pitching well and a Sandy Amorós home run, the Dodgers winning five to three. The Series stood at three games to two for Brooklyn when it returned to Yankee Stadium for Games Six and Seven. Game Six the Yankees won, five to one, behind Whitey Ford. Tied at three. Game Seven was Podres against Tommy Byrne. Podres was twenty-three. Podres had grown up in Witherbee, New York, three hundred miles up the Hudson, in iron-mining country, and he had been pitching in the Dodgers' organization since 1951. Game Seven was his second start of the Series. He had won Game Three. The afternoon of Game Seven he

ate a steak for breakfast at the Concourse Plaza Hotel, walked to Yankee Stadium, and threw what would later be remembered as one of the most disciplined complete-game shutouts in the history of the World Series. He went the full nine. He gave up eight hits. He walked two. He struck out four. He held the Yankee lineup, which had averaged five and a half runs a game during the regular season, to zero. The Dodgers scored a run in the fourth inning when Hodges singled in Campanella, who had doubled. The Dodgers scored a run in the sixth inning on a Hodges sacrifice fly that brought home Reese. That was all the runs. Two to nothing. In the bottom of the sixth, with two on, one out, and Berra at the plate, Walter Alston walked out from the dugout and made his only managerial decision of the afternoon that anyone would remember for the next seventy years. He called Junior Gilliam in from left field and put him at second base. He called Don Zimmer off the bench. He sent Amorós to left. Berra came up. The pitch was a fastball low and away. Berra, an aggressive opposite-field hitter when he had to be, sliced it down the left-field line, and you have already read what happened next. What you have not read is what Vin Scully said in the bottom of the ninth, after Howard's roller, after Reese's throw, after the catch at first. What Vin said, after the famous nine words, was nothing. He let the

Mutual broadcast hold the silence and let the Yankee Stadium crowd carry it. In Brooklyn — in living rooms, on stoops, on barstools, in the diners and the bakeries where the radios had been on all afternoon, the borough cried. The borough had won. The next morning, the New York Daily News ran the photograph of Pee Wee Reese hugging Johnny Podres on the field at Yankee Stadium, beneath a headline that, in the inverted vernacular of the borough, said the only thing the borough wanted to say. *WHO'S A BUM!* Two months later, the Brooklyn Eagle, which had folded in January of that same year, would not have to print a paper about it. The borough printed it themselves, in conversation, on every corner, for the rest of the autumn. — Vin Scully would later say, in any number of interviews across the next sixty years, that calling the final out of the 1955 World Series was the most difficult thing he had ever done in a microphone, because it required him to do, in the most extraordinary moment of his life to that point, exactly what Red Barber had taught him six years earlier, which was to do almost nothing at all. The borough's joy, he said, was not his job. The borough's joy was the borough's. His job was to identify, in nine words or fewer, the fact that had just become true, and then to step out of the way and let the borough have it. He stepped out of the way. The borough had it. It would

have it for two more seasons before it lost the team to a city it could not yet pronounce, three thousand miles to the west, where the Pacific was warmer and the orange groves had not yet been bulldozed. But the borough does not yet know that. In October of 1955, the borough has just won. The borough is going to be all right. Pull up a chair. — chapter: 5 title: The Move arm: blue_heaven status: draft v1 sources_dossier: ../sources/ch05_the_move.md voice_check: 80% Scully / 20% Steinbeck — migration prose — # Chapter 5 ### The Move The press release that broke the borough was issued from the offices of the Brooklyn Dodgers, Inc., at 215 Montague Street in downtown Brooklyn, on the afternoon of October 8, 1957. It was four sentences long. It said, in language that had been worked over by the team's attorneys for a week, that in view of the inability to obtain a satisfactory location for a new ballpark in the city of New York, the directors of the Brooklyn Dodgers had voted to transfer the franchise to Los Angeles, California, beginning with the 1958 season. The release was signed by the team president. The team president was Walter Francis O'Malley. In the borough, the press release was received the way a death notice is received. In the borough, depending on which kitchen you were standing in or which subway car you were riding, the man who had signed it was a

businessman, an opportunist, a thief, a serpent, or, in the formulation of one of the borough's most enduring jokes, one of the three worst people in human history, the others being Hitler and Stalin, in some order, with O'Malley running second. What he was, in fact, was a real-estate man. Which is the same thing as saying that what he was, in fact, was a man who had looked at the corner of Atlantic and Flatbush, where he had wanted to build a new domed stadium for the Brooklyn Dodgers, and had been told by a New York City parks commissioner named Robert Moses, who in 1957 controlled approximately every shovelful of public land in the city, that he could not have the parcel he wanted, that he could have a different parcel in Queens that he did not want, and that the conversation about Brooklyn was, as far as Robert Moses was concerned, over. O'Malley took the conversation to Los Angeles. The mayor of Los Angeles, a man named Norris Poulson, took it back. What Poulson offered O'Malley was, in the language of the deal, three hundred acres of city-owned land in a neighborhood called Chavez Ravine, north of downtown, where there had once been a small Mexican-American community that the city had cleared for a public-housing project that had then been canceled, and where the land had been sitting, half-graded and weedy, since 1953. Poulson would deed

the land to the Dodgers. The Dodgers would build a stadium on it. The mayor's office would handle the political theater. In Brooklyn, the press release went out on October 8. In Los Angeles, on October 9, the morning newspapers ran headlines that said, more or less, *we have a major-league team*. In Brooklyn, the borough went into mourning. It mourned all winter. It mourned through Christmas. It mourned through the first months of 1958. It mourned in stages — the way a family mourns a parent, in shock, then in anger, then in slow accommodation. The owner who had taken the team did not return to the borough. The newspapers that had run the team's box scores for the previous seventy-three years began running, instead, the box scores of the New York Yankees and the New York Giants, the second of whom, perhaps not coincidentally, had also moved that same autumn, to a city in California called San Francisco, where they would play in a windswept stadium named Seals Stadium until a bigger park called Candlestick could be built. New York, in the autumn of 1957, lost two of its three major-league franchises in eight days. The borough lost the only one it cared about. Vin Scully, who had spent the previous eight years of his life calling Brooklyn baseball — who had moved into a small apartment near the elevated subway in Bay Ridge, who had introduced himself, on summer

evenings, to the cab drivers and the deli men and the dock workers who knew him by his voice and not his face, who had stood next to Red Barber in the booth at Ebbets Field and had been told, by Barber, that the borough's relationship with the team was the most beautiful and most unrequited love affair in American sport — packed his Brooklyn life into a station wagon, in February of 1958, and drove west. He was twenty-nine. He was about to call major-league baseball, for the first time, in a city that had never had any. — To understand what the city Vin drove into was like in the spring of 1958, you have to imagine, briefly, a Los Angeles that was still legible. A city that had not yet been swallowed by the freeway grid. A city that ended, on its eastern edge, at the foothills above Pasadena, and on its western edge, at the dunes north of Santa Monica, with a center of gravity downtown — where the Bradbury Building still smelled like the rust on the iron banisters and the streetcars still ran along Spring Street and the grand old movie palaces along Broadway still showed second-run pictures to crowds of clerks and waitresses on lunch breaks. The city had palms, but not yet the tall ones along the west side that television cameras would later turn into the city's signature. The city had a freeway, singular, that connected downtown

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